

FAR-SIDS Systematic Review Protocol

Foreign aid, remittances, and wellbeing in Small Island Developing States: a systematic review of methods, variables, and evidence.

Version 1.4, updated 10 July 2026 (macro stratum amendment and screening housekeeping recorded at the close of title and abstract screening, see the calibration record in section 3; v1.3 of 3 July 2026 had clarified that the wellbeing or livelihood outcome criterion is applied broadly; v1.2 of 30 June 2026 had set the date window to the last 20 years and added Spanish to the languages, following supervisor feedback; v1.1 had aligned the databases, de-duplication, the two-search design, and the eligibility criteria with what was carried out). Prepared by Roxane de Waegh (MSCA Fellow, ISSI, University of Malta), with Professor Stefano Moncada (supervisor). Intended for registration on OSF Registries. Follows the PRISMA 2020 reporting guideline and the PRISMA-P protocol structure.

This is Paper 1 of the FAR-SIDS fellowship. It is bound for DevNet 2026 in Wellington (abstract due end of August 2026), and it does double duty: it maps the existing evidence, and it feeds the variable selection for the econometric work, which is why it links Work Package 5 with Work Package 7.

1. Background and rationale

Small Island Developing States receive some of the world's largest flows of foreign aid and remittances relative to the size of their economies, yet the evidence on how those flows translate into wellbeing and livelihoods on the ground is scattered across disciplines and methods. This review maps that evidence systematically: what has been studied, with which methods and models, drawing on which variables, and whether any prior work has combined ethnography, household surveys, and time series econometrics in a single design. The conceptual frame is the Sustainable Livelihoods Framework read through the aid and remittance nexus, against the three FAR-SIDS case countries, Jamaica, Tonga, and Comoros. The review is framed against the State of SIDS Report 2026 from ODI Global.

2. Objectives and review questions

The review answers four questions, carried from the supervision meeting of 24 June 2026: What has already been studied on foreign aid and remittances in relation to wellbeing and livelihoods in SIDS, and where are the gaps?

Which methods and models were used, with particular attention to time series econometrics (ARDL), ethnography, and household surveys?

Has any prior work combined ethnography, household surveys, and ARDL econometrics in one design? This is the project's methodological claim to novelty, so it needs an evidence based answer.

Which dependent and independent variables did those studies use? This part directly feeds the FAR-SIDS variable list.

Framed as a single question: among studies of SIDS and comparable small economies, how do foreign aid and remittances relate to wellbeing and livelihood outcomes, what methods and variables have been used to measure that relationship, and has any study integrated ethnography, household surveys, and ARDL econometrics?

3. Eligibility criteria

Include a study if it meets all of the following:

Empirical (data collected and analysed, through econometrics, household surveys, ethnography, or mixed methods), or a strong conceptual contribution (a structured framework, theory, or evidence grounded argument), on foreign aid or remittances, or both.

Reports a wellbeing or livelihood outcome (for example welfare, poverty, food security, human development, resilience, standard of living, or a livelihoods dimension). This criterion is applied

broadly: resilience includes community, societal, and regional resilience, not only the household level, and the wellbeing pathway may be indirect. A study of aid or remittance policy qualifies where the policy plausibly bears on the wellbeing or livelihoods of people in the affected states, for example a study of aid as a geopolitical or security instrument whose programmes build resilience in, and affect the populations of, recipient states. A study whose outcomes are only macroeconomic (for example growth, exchange rates, or financial development) qualifies where foreign aid or remittances is the object of study and the setting criterion below is met; such studies form a distinct macro stratum, extracted for their variables, data sources, and methods to inform the FAR-SIDS models (Work Package 5), and reported as context in the synthesis rather than as wellbeing evidence. A study where aid or remittances appears only as a control variable or as background context does not qualify.

Set in a Small Island Developing State, or in a small economy whose findings transfer to the SIDS context.

Peer reviewed literature, or substantial grey literature (an institutional report with a clear method or data, for example from the World Bank, IMF, ODI, UNCTAD, or regional development banks; not a blog, press release, or think piece).

Written in English, French, or Spanish (French for the Comoros literature; Spanish for the wider Caribbean and Latin American literature).

Published within the last 20 years (2006 to present), following the supervisor's guidance. The exact cutoff is recorded and applied at screening.

Exclude a study if it is:

A macroeconomic study in which foreign aid or remittances is not the object of study but appears only as a control variable or background context. These are logged with the reason "not about aid or remittances". The size of the macro literature relative to the wellbeing literature remains a reported finding, captured through the macro stratum of included studies.

An opinion piece, editorial, commentary, op-ed, or news item that only asserts a view, with no empirical or strong conceptual contribution.

An existing systematic or literature review on this topic. These are not included as studies; their reference lists are instead mined through citation searching, to avoid double counting.

Not retrievable in full text after reasonable effort. This reason applies at the full text stage only; at title and abstract screening, a record that cannot be judged is retained under the doubt rule rather than excluded.

These criteria are fixed in this protocol before screening begins. They are calibrated with the supervisor on an early batch of about fifty records, and any wording change made during calibration is recorded and dated.

Calibration record. 3 July 2026, at roughly 20 percent of title and abstract screening (227 of 1,133 records, single reviewer): the wellbeing or livelihood outcome criterion was clarified to be applied broadly, as now worded above. The prompting case was a study of Japan's Official Development Assistance and Official Security Assistance as instruments of deterrence and regional resilience, which reports no household level outcome but concerns aid policy that bears on the populations of recipient states. The reviewer's decision was to include such studies, reading resilience beyond the household level and accepting indirect wellbeing pathways, while keeping the growth-only exclusion unchanged. This reading reflects how the criterion has been applied since screening began. To be reviewed with the supervisor at the meeting of Wednesday 8 July 2026; any resulting change will be recorded here with its date.

Calibration record. 10 July 2026, at the close of title and abstract screening (single reviewer, assisted by an AI consistency check over the full pool of 1,133 records before locking the stage): the growth-only exclusion was found to conflate two different situations, studies where aid or remittances is merely a control variable, and studies where the flow is the object of study in a SIDS or transferable small economy setting but the outcomes are macroeconomic only. The criterion is amended as now worded above: the latter are included as a distinct macro stratum, extracted for variables, data sources, and methods, and synthesised as context; the former remain excluded under "not about aid or remittances". On the same date the exclusion reason labels were harmonised to the protocol wording, the reason "not retrievable in full text" was

reserved for the full text stage, and three records mistakenly labelled as duplicates during screening were re-reasoned (duplicates are handled at de-duplication and reported in the flow diagram; Rayyan removed 21 duplicate records from the 1,154 imported, leaving the screening pool of 1,133). To be confirmed with the supervisor.

4. Information sources

Two arms, both reported in the PRISMA flow diagram.

Arm one, database searches (the reproducible core). Scopus, Web of Science, EBSCO Academic Search Ultimate, and EconBiz for the auditable search, and Google Scholar for additional coverage and grey literature. EconLit was the planned economics database, but it is not in the University of Malta subscription, so EBSCO Academic Search Ultimate and the free economics database EconBiz (ZBW) were used in its place. For each database the exact search string, the date run, and the number of records retrieved are recorded in the companion search log.

Arm two, other methods. Citation searching (both backward, screening the reference lists of key reports and included studies, and forward, the works that cite them), and targeted searching of grey literature sources (the World Bank, IMF, ODI, UNCTAD, and regional development banks). Records found this way are logged separately and counted in the “other methods” column of the flow diagram.

The full search strings are held in the companion document, FAR-SIDS_search_strings, and summarised in section 5.

5. Search strategy

The core search combines three concept blocks with AND: the flows (foreign aid, official development assistance, ODA, remittances), the outcomes (wellbeing, livelihoods, welfare, poverty, human development, resilience), and the setting (small island developing states, SIDS, small states, island economies, Pacific, Caribbean, Indian Ocean, and the three case countries). A fourth, methods block (ARDL, cointegration, time series, ethnography, household survey, mixed methods) is applied as a refinement to answer the methods and integration questions. Two searches are run in each database. A broad mapping search captures studies on either flow, aid or remittances, with an outcome in the SIDS setting. A targeted nexus search requires both foreign aid and remittances in the same study, to surface the rare work that examines them together. The contrast between a large mapping set and a very small nexus set is itself evidence of the gap. Strings are first run as drafted, then refined once after inspecting the first returns, and the final locked version is recorded with its date.

6. A note on scoping versus the counted search

This section exists to draw the line that the protocol is built to draw.

Not everything done in this review is counted in the PRISMA flow diagram. What is counted are the searches declared in this protocol: the database searches in section 4 arm one, and the citation and grey literature searches in section 4 arm two. Both are applied under the eligibility criteria in section 3, and the number of records in and out is logged at every step.

What is not counted is the scoping that precedes the locked protocol: the exploratory use of citation mapping tools (Connected Papers, Research Rabbit, Litmaps) and AI semantic tools (Elicit, Consensus) to learn the field, identify seed papers, and refine the search terms. This work is essential and is reported briefly in the methods as how the search was developed, but it is not a counted source, because its results are not fully reproducible.

The practical test: triage becomes counted screening the moment it is done under the fixed eligibility criteria, with the numbers recorded. Reading the references of the State of SIDS Report 2026 and keeping the relevant ones is citation searching, and it counts, provided the same criteria and logging are applied. The same act done loosely, before the criteria are fixed, to get a feel for the field, is scoping, and it does not. The criteria and the log are what move an activity from one side of the line to the other.

7. Study records and selection process

Data management. All records are exported to the FAR-SIDS Zotero group library, then combined and de-duplicated in two stages: the TERA Deduplicator (Bond University, Focused algorithm), followed by Rayyan's own duplicate detection. Of 1,690 records identified across the four databases, 557 duplicates were removed (536 in TERA, 21 in Rayyan), leaving 1,133 unique records. Title and abstract screening is done in Rayyan, single reviewer, with the supervisor reviewing an early batch. The PRISMA running counts are maintained as screening proceeds.

Selection. Identification: all records from both arms exported to Zotero, then de-duplicated.

Screening: titles and abstracts in Rayyan, against the section 3 criteria, calibrated with the supervisor on an early batch of about fifty. Eligibility: full text review of records that pass.

Included: the final set carried into extraction. The number entering and leaving at each stage is logged for the PRISMA 2020 flow diagram, with reasons recorded at the full text stage.

8. Data extraction

One row per included study in a structured evidence table, with fixed fields: citation; country or region; aid, remittances, or both; outcome (dependent) variables; independent variables; data source and years; method; whether ethnography, household survey, econometrics, or a combination; key finding; and a note on quality or limitations. This table is the heart of the paper and the bridge to the FAR-SIDS variable list. Extracted values are checked against the source.

9. Synthesis

A narrative and tabular synthesis organised around the four review questions. No meta-analysis is planned, because the methods and outcomes are expected to be too heterogeneous to pool. Particular weight falls on two columns: the variables, which become the candidate list for the FAR-SIDS econometric models, and the integration question, which is where the paper stakes its contribution. The macro stratum of included studies, where aid or remittances is the object of study but the outcomes are macroeconomic only, is characterised descriptively as context, to show how a wellbeing and livelihoods lens differs from the existing macroeconomic work. Study quality and limitations are appraised descriptively and carried into the synthesis rather than through a single formal risk of bias instrument, given the mixed methods nature of the evidence.

10. Registration, reporting, and roles

The protocol is registered on OSF Registries for transparency (PROSPERO is reserved largely for health reviews). Reporting follows PRISMA 2020, including the flow diagram. Roxane de Waegh leads the review; Professor Stefano Moncada supervises and reviews the early screening batch. Provisional milestones: search terms and protocol locked in July 2026, first searches and screening across July and August, abstract submitted to DevNet 2026 by the end of August 2026, with the variable list emerging from the evidence table to feed Work Package 5.

11. Items still to confirm with the supervisor

These are left open for the working meeting, and do not block the start of screening: Whether to restrict by document type. The date window is now set at the last 20 years, and the languages at English, French, and Spanish, per the supervisor.

Whether the supervisor endorses the broad application of the wellbeing or livelihood outcome criterion recorded in the section 3 calibration record of 3 July 2026.

Whether a second screener is added beyond the supervisor's review of the early batch, and how any disagreements are resolved.

Whether to register on OSF now or after the first screening returns.